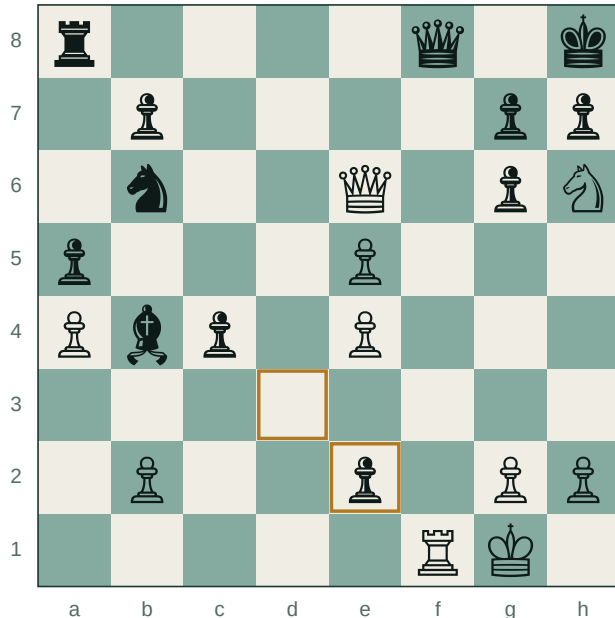


# Smothered mates: White, move 26

Smothered mates

White to move



Previous move: 25...dxe2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

**WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST**

**26. Rxf8+ Rxf8 27. Qg8+ Rxg8 28. Nf7#**

**26.Rxf8+** Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. From f8 it attacks king on h8 and rook on a8. Recorded reply: **26...Rxf8.**

**27.Qg8+** Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From g8 it attacks king on h8 and rook on f8. Recorded reply: **27...Rxg8.**

**28.Nf7#** Mate: knight on f7 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

**CHECKPOINT**

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Knight on f7. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

**CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES**

A familiar pattern is insufficient if the knight can be captured. Verify protection and every legal king move.

**WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES**

A knight can check a king surrounded by its own pieces. Those pieces become a cage because a knight check cannot be blocked.

**HOW TO LOOK**

Trace the knight's route to the checking square and identify the enemy pieces that deny the king its escape squares.

The defending king is on h8. Geometrically undefended: knight on b6. Check for tactical protection.